

The Missing Link of Environmental Justice: When Deprivation is Ignored

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Overview of Research

Environmental racism is the intentional racial discrimination in which predominantly minority communities are disproportionately targeted for the siting of polluting industries. With the increase in environmental racism issues in the 1980's, the environmental justice movement was launched. Environmentalists typically focus on the preservation of Earth's natural resources, environmental protection, global warming and the protection of ecosystems, leaving environmental justice issues in the shadows. The fight for civil and human rights for environmental equity is mainly ignored by large corporations, state and local government and environmentalists. This study sets out to detail how the lack of attention on these issues by environmentalists indirectly contributes to the suppression of information surrounding environmental justice issues. Keeping environmental issues off the agenda prevents the movement from receiving mainstream attention.

Methods

•Literature review data was collected from the online database Academic Search Premier and Google Scholar.

•The books utilized for the literature review were collected from the University of Minnesota's Wilson Library.

• The key words environmentalism, elitism, racism, environmental justice, environmental movement, history and environmental were utilized for both Academic Search Premier and Google Scholar.

•Articles were coded from Earth First Journals published between the years of 1990-1993, the articles were categorized by the topics of the articles and compiled into a bar graph.



images Courtesy of University of North Texas Center for Environmental Philosophy

Literature Review

Environmental Justice Movement:

•The environmental justice movement emerged in response to the detrimental health ailments and poor environmental conditions endured by minorities in lower class communities.

•In communities with two or more commercial hazardous waste facilities or one or more of the nation's five largest landfills, the average minority percentage of the population was more than three times that of communities without facilities. (Austin and Schill, 1991; Mohai ET. AL, 2009)

Environmentalist Movement:

• In the century between 1890-1990 the organization style of environmental groups has evolved from democratic to voluntary.

•The framing of environmental movements has expanded, environmental protection policies have been mandated and the focus has widened. (Lester, 1995; Selle and Stromsnes, 1998; Pellow, 1999)

Elitism within Environmentalist Movement:

•The elitist argument has been tossed around repeatedly by scholars with the majority of the explanations being broken down into three components, including compositional, ideological and impact elitism. (Morrison and Dunlap, 1986)

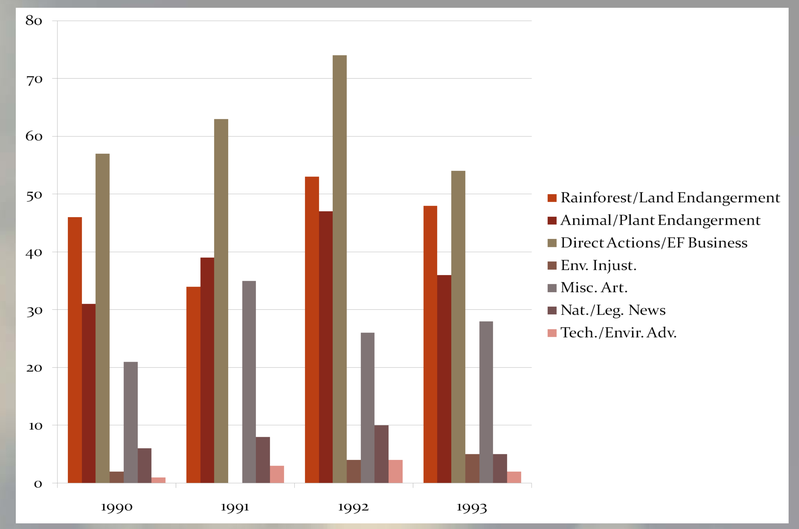
•The compositional elitism argument proclaims that supporters and members of environmental movements are drawn directly from upper socioeconomic strata. (Morrison and Dunlap, 1986)

•The ideological elitism argument proclaims that environmental reform proposals have the underlying purpose of distributing benefits to environmentalists and costs to underprivileged non-environmentalist. (Morrison and Dunlap, 1986)

• The impact elitism argument proclaims that environmental reforms whether intentionally or not have distributed benefits to environmentalists and costs to non- environmentalists. (Morrison and Dunlap, 1986)

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Results



Discussion

• The content of 9 Earth First Journals ranging from the years of 1990-1993 were assessed based on article content.

• The content from each journal was divided into the 7 categories.

• Only 11 out of 700 plus articles were related to environmental justice.

• The results support the hypothesis in regarding to the tendency of environmentalists to ignore issues of environmental justice.

•The most frequent occurring article was based on direct actions against animal cruelty or land protection or preservation.

Implications

• The lack of attention paid to environmental justice issues by environmentalists further perpetuates racial and classist elitism and contributes to environmental racism.

•Environmental protection must include issues of social justice in order for the movement to be all inclusive and more effective.